The 36 Stratagems in the Mirror

Yin and Yang as a Principle of Strategic Analysis – Complete Edition

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> **Edition note:** This work is an analytical and didactic tool. It does not reconstruct any historically transmitted Yin versions of the stratagems and makes no claim to empirically demonstrated superiority. The number 72 is the arithmetic result of doubling the perspectives, not an independent theoretical contribution.

> **Intellectual impetus from Prof. Dr. Christian Rieck:** The classic 36 stratagems have fascinated people for centuries as instructions for active shaping. From a game-theoretic and systemic perspective, however, a strategy is never one-sided. Every action contains the seed of its own defense as well as of the conscious change of roles. This work extends the traditional Eastern doctrine of strategy by the mirror-image Yin perspective and the dynamics of constant transformation.

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1 Introduction: A Strategy Has Two Sides

The 36 Stratagems are among the best-known collections of strategic thinking from China. They describe ways of influencing situations, deceiving opponents, shifting balances of power, exploiting opportunities, or extricating oneself from an unfavorable position.

Each of these patterns can be viewed from two interconnected directions of effect:

- **Yang** stands for active application: intention, deployment and intended effect.
- **Yin** stands for recognizing the same logic of effect from the position of the person affected, and the countermeasure derived from it.

Strategic mastery in this model means not only being able to deploy a pattern successfully, but also recognizing it when it is directed against oneself and, where sensible, changing perspective: from the one who recognizes to the one who applies.

Clarification of the claim: The model is a didactic and analytical tool. It claims neither to reconstruct historical Yin versions nor to possess empirically demonstrated superiority. The number 72 results purely arithmetically from doubling the perspectives and is not an independent theoretical contribution.

1.1 What the Revised Edition Delivers

This edition bundles the recurring Yin core operations into a testable analysis checklist with six guiding questions, replaces generic examples with case-based scenarios with check steps, provides a worked case example as a model, explicitly names the limits of the model, and addresses the core question: What happens when both sides play mirror-aware?

2 Methodological Foundation

2.1 The Four Levels of Analysis

Each stratagem is unlocked along four levels:

1. **Core idea** – the abstract logic of effect of the pattern.
2. **Yang – Application** – how the pattern is actively deployed.
3. **Yin – Recognition and Counteraction** – how it is recognized and parried.
4. **Switch** – the conscious transition from the one who recognizes to the one who applies.

In addition comes the mirror thought: the insight that the same logic applies to both sides and shows itself differently depending on position.

2.2 The Six Yin Core Operations as an Analysis Checklist

A critical review of all 36 Yin pages shows that they can be traced back to six recurring core operations. These are formulated as testable guiding questions – not as mnemonics, but as test steps:

Core operation	Guiding question	Concrete check step
Information hygiene	What is claim, what is evidence?	Separate presentation from substance; check origin, motives and corroboration; obtain an independent second source.
Option preservation	Which alternatives are disappearing right now?	Secure exit paths in advance; detect the narrowing of options early; document switching costs.
Cui bono	Who actually benefits from the situation?	Disclose interests; limit instrumentalizability; distinguish beneficiaries from those who steer.
Boundary setting	Where do my mandate, my access, my responsibility end?	Set clear boundaries; restrict access narrowly; minimize rights; define review points.
Time control	Who dictates pace and deadlines?	Set deadlines yourself; recognize time consumption as a means of power; document gains from delay.
Escalation control	What does my countermeasure trigger?	Anticipate feedback; play through the counter-counter-reaction; examine the de-escalation option.

Applying the checklist: Before any reaction to a suspected stratagem, the six guiding questions are worked through in a fixed order. The order is deliberate: *first recognize (1–4), then act and check the action (5–6)*. Only when all six have been answered is a countermeasure chosen. This prevents reflexive counter-force and makes the Yin side operational.

2.3 Assignment Matrix of the 36 Stratagems

The following matrix makes the reduction from Section 2.2 verifiable: For each of the 36 stratagems, it shows which of the six core operations its Yin entry and its countermeasure in Chapter 3 require.

> **Reading note:** ● = main focus, ○ = secondary aspect. Every stratagem has at least one main focus; Stratagem 9 has two, so the sum of main foci is 37. The assignment is based on the author's reading, not on an independent coding; borderline cases are a matter of judgment.

No.	Stratagem	Information hygiene	Option preservation	Cui bono	Boundary setting	Time control	Escalation control
Part I: Stratagems of Deception and Camouflage							
1	Deceive the Heavens to Cross the Sea	●			○		
2	Besiege Wei to Rescue Zhao	●					
3	Kill with a Borrowed Knife	○		●			
4	Wait at Ease as the Enemy Tires		○	○		●	
5	Plunder a Burning House	●			○	○	
6	Make Noise in the East, Attack in the West	●					
Part II: Stratagems against the Enemy							
7	Create Something from Nothing	●					
8	Secretly March to Chencang	●					
9	Watch the Fire on the Opposite Shore		○	●			●

No.	Stratagem	Information hygiene	Option preservation	Cui bono	Boundary setting	Time control	Escalation control
10	Hide the Dagger Behind a Smile	●					
11	Sacrifice the Plum Tree for the Peach Tree			●	○		
12	Take the Sheep in Passing	○			●		
Part III: Stratagems of Attack							
13	Beat the Grass to Startle the Snake						●
14	Lend a Body to a Dead Soul	●					
15	Lure the Tiger Out of the Mountains		●	○			
16	Let Escape First in Order to Catch		●				
17	Toss Out a Brick to Obtain Jade	●	○				
18	Capture the Leader		●				
Part IV: Stratagems in Confused Situations							
19	Pull the Firewood from under the Cauldron		●				
20	Fish in Troubled Waters	●					
21	The Cicada Sheds Its Shell	●			○		
22	Shut the Door to Catch the Thief		●				
23	Ally with the Distant, Attack the Near		●	○			
24	Borrow the Road to Conquer Guo				●	○	
Part V: Stratagems for Changing Positions							
25	Steal the Beams, Replace the Pillars				●		
26	Point at the Mulberry Tree, Rebuke the Acacia Tree	●		○			
27	Feign Stupidity Without Losing Your Wits	●					
28	Remove the Ladder After the Opponent Has Climbed Up		●				
29	Hang Artificial Blossoms on Trees	●					
30	Turn from Guest into Host		○		●		
Part VI: Stratagems in Difficult Situations							
31	The Beauty Trap	●		○			
32	The Empty City	●					
33	Turn the Opponent’s Spy	●					
34	Injure Oneself	○		●			
35	Chain Strategies				●		
36	Retreat as the Best Strategy		○				●

Distribution across all 36 stratagems	Information hygiene	Option preservation	Cui bono	Boundary setting	Time control	Escalation control
Main focus (●)	17	7	4	5	1	3
Secondary aspect (○)	3	5	5	4	2	0

3 The 36 Stratagems in the Mirror

> **Editorial note:** The following entries have been standardized. Duplicate entries were merged, fragmented passages put in order. Each entry follows the same scheme: Core idea – Yang – Yin – Switch – Case example – Countermeasure – Mirror thought.

Part I: Stratagems of Deception and Camouflage (1–6)

1. Deceive the Heavens to Cross the Sea

- **Core idea:** Using the familiar to conceal an unusual action.
- **Yang – Application:** An action is carried out so ordinarily that others see no reason to suspect a particular intention.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Read the very self-evidence as a possible camouflage signal; check changes of responsibility and shifts of resources.
- **Switch:** Whoever has recognized that normality serves as cover can deliberately create normality themselves.
- **Case example:** A company communicates a far-reaching organizational change as a “routine administrative adjustment” – with new approval rights and altered reporting lines.
- **Countermeasure:** Document actual changes to responsibilities and rights; review changes to decision-making authority separately, not only the communicated justification.
- **Mirror thought:** What serves one party as camouflage can serve the other as an indication of deliberately created normality.

2. Besiege Wei to Rescue Zhao

- **Core idea:** Not attacking where the opponent is strong, but tying up their forces elsewhere.
- **Yang – Application:** Creating pressure at a sensitive point.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check whether the attack serves primarily as a distraction; correlation of place of attack and announced target.
- **Switch:** Open secondary theaters of your own.
- **Case example:** A competitor provokes in a side segment (e.g., a price promotion in a niche) while quiet customer poaching is under way in the core business.
- **Countermeasure:** Defend the core business; do not shift resources to the side theater; monitor churn rates in the core segment.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever exerts pressure steers attention.

3. Kill with a Borrowed Knife

- **Core idea:** Deploying the forces of others to achieve one’s own goal.
- **Yang – Application:** Getting other persons to take an action.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Cui-bono analysis: Who profits? Who steers? Who is liable?
- **Switch:** Reverse the constellation.
- **Case example:** Two departments are in conflict; a third department supplies information that fuels the conflict without becoming visible itself.
- **Countermeasure:** Make the interest situation transparent; consider information providers and beneficiaries separately.
- **Mirror thought:** The visible hand need not be the steering hand.

4. Wait at Ease as the Enemy Tires

- **Core idea:** Preserving one's own strength and waiting for the right moment.
- **Yang – Application:** Avoiding unnecessary exertion.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Set pace and deadlines yourself; check who benefits from the time consumed.
- **Switch:** Dictate the pace yourself.
- **Case example:** A negotiating partner delays every round and refers to "internal coordination."
- **Countermeasure:** Define deadlines; check the counterparty's capacity to negotiate; negotiate alternatives in parallel.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever waits for the moment exploits the other's time consumption.

5. Plunder a Burning House

- **Core idea:** Exploiting crisis or disorder.
- **Yang – Application:** Using a situation in which others are preoccupied with problems.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Separate emergency measures from concessions; check whether the crisis is the occasion or the pretext.
- **Switch:** Act prepared in the crises of others.
- **Case example:** A supplier uses a technical outage to renegotiate price and delivery terms.
- **Countermeasure:** Decouple; negotiate emergency agreements and regular contract changes separately.
- **Mirror thought:** One party's crisis is another's advantage.

6. Make Noise in the East, Attack in the West

- **Core idea:** Directing attention in one direction.
- **Yang – Application:** Creating conspicuous activity.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Examine the loudest activity; correlation of announcement and actual resource movement.
- **Switch:** Make noise yourself.
- **Case example:** Harmless security notices pile up while a quiet takeover is being prepared.
- **Countermeasure:** Correlate: compare announcements with capital, personnel and legal movements.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever steers attention influences decisions.

Part II: Stratagems against the Enemy (7–12)

7. Create Something from Nothing

- **Core idea:** Creating perception through apparent existence.
- **Yang – Application:** Presenting a threat.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Distinguish between claim and reality; demand evidence.
- **Switch:** Work with perception in a controlled way.
- **Case example:** A market participant announces a product that does not yet exist in order to tie up the competition.
- **Countermeasure:** Demand verifiable milestones; do not treat announcements as market data.
- **Mirror thought:** Perceived existence can have real effect – even without substance.

8. Secretly March to Chencang

- **Core idea:** Announcing a visible course of action while pursuing a different plan.
- **Yang – Application:** Creating expectations.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Observe plans and resources separately.
- **Switch:** Use announcements as cover.
- **Case example:** A public market announcement for segment A, while budget and personnel are shifted to segment B.
- **Countermeasure:** Observe real activities: budget flows, hiring, patent filings.
- **Mirror thought:** The visible direction is not the real direction.

9. Watch the Fire on the Opposite Shore

- **Core idea:** Waiting while others become embroiled in conflict.
- **Yang – Application:** Letting the conflict cost resources.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check the benefit for third parties; question the spectator position.
- **Switch:** Enter the conflicts of others.
- **Case example:** Price dumping between two competitors; a third stays out of it and gains market share.
- **Countermeasure:** Do not continue; check your own position and capacity for alliances.
- **Mirror thought:** Not every spectator is neutral.

10. Hide the Dagger Behind a Smile

- **Core idea:** Using a friendly demeanor.
- **Yang – Application:** Building trust while pursuing the goal.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Separate social impression and consequences.
- **Switch:** Maintain a cooperative surface.
- **Case example:** Praise accompanying one-sided contracts; friendly support for a disadvantageous arrangement.
- **Countermeasure:** Check the consequences; compare the contract text with the communicated intent.
- **Mirror thought:** Friendliness and conflict of interest exist at the same time.

11. Sacrifice the Plum Tree for the Peach Tree

- **Core idea:** Accepting a limited loss.
- **Yang – Application:** Sacrificing a resource in order to preserve something more important.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Who defines the loss? Who profits from the logic of sacrifice?
- **Switch:** Decide yourself what is sacrificed.
- **Case example:** A department gives up resources in order to secure its own justification for existing.
- **Countermeasure:** Transparency about sacrifice and gain; check who has the authority to decide on the sacrifice.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever chooses the loss influences the gain.

12. Take the Sheep in Passing

- **Core idea:** Using small opportunities.
- **Yang – Application:** Taking an advantage along the way.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Close inattention at the margins; check incidental concessions.
- **Switch:** Search systematically for advantages.
- **Case example:** Unclear contract wording that creates a small advantage with every billing.
- **Countermeasure:** Regulate unambiguously; check side agreements and trivial clauses.
- **Mirror thought:** Incidental opportunity is unnoticed loss.

Part III: Stratagems of Attack (13–18)

13. Beat the Grass to Startle the Snake

- **Core idea:** Provoking a reaction, obtaining information.
- **Yang – Application:** Setting a targeted stimulus.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Treat provocation as a test; dose the reaction.
- **Switch:** Set stimuli yourself.
- **Case example:** A targeted question about a new product to test response time and state of information.
- **Countermeasure:** Dose information; choose the reaction deliberately.
- **Mirror thought:** Reaction is a source of information.

14. Lend a Body to a Dead Soul

- **Core idea:** Reviving an old idea in a new form.
- **Yang – Application:** Using a well-known name.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check the substance behind the label.
- **Switch:** Use existing names.
- **Case example:** A product takes over an old name but changes its features and pricing model.
- **Countermeasure:** Check features, prices and contract terms, not the name.
- **Mirror thought:** A familiar name guarantees no substance.

15. Lure the Tiger Out of the Mountains

- **Core idea:** Bringing the opponent out of a strong position.
- **Yang – Application:** Changing the situation.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check the incentive; check whether your own position is thereby weakened.
- **Switch:** Pull others out of their position.
- **Case example:** An attempted price war meant to lure the market leader out of its premium position.
- **Countermeasure:** Do not switch; hold position and pricing strategy.
- **Mirror thought:** Strength becomes weakness in the wrong environment.

16. Let Escape First in Order to Catch

- **Core idea:** Leaving room in order to bind.
- **Yang – Application:** Relinquishing control.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Preserve exit options; check commitments.
- **Switch:** Grant freedom in measured doses.
- **Case example:** A seemingly favorable decision with high later switching costs.
- **Countermeasure:** Check commitments and switching costs in advance.
- **Mirror thought:** Granted latitude steers behavior.

17. Toss Out a Brick to Obtain Jade

- **Core idea:** Offering a small value for a greater one.
- **Yang – Application:** Using a small incentive.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check the strategic price; assess the consideration.
- **Switch:** Use small incentives in a controlled way.
- **Case example:** A free initial offer coupled with a long-term commitment.
- **Countermeasure:** Calculate total costs over the term; check couplings.
- **Mirror thought:** The small value is the price of the large one.

18. Capture the Leader

- **Core idea:** Attacking a node.
- **Yang – Application:** Concentrating on a central function.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Build redundancies; check dependencies.
- **Switch:** Attack the nodes of others.
- **Case example:** Dependence on a single person or a single supplier.
- **Countermeasure:** Deputies and redundancy; dependency analysis.
- **Mirror thought:** Centralized strength is a vulnerability.

Part IV: Stratagems in Confused Situations (19–24)

19. Pull the Firewood from under the Cauldron

- **Core idea:** Attacking the cause, not the effect.
- **Yang – Application:** Changing basic conditions.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Protect your own prerequisites; cause analysis.
- **Switch:** Attack the structures of others.
- **Case example:** Unstable energy supply as a lever against production sites.
- **Countermeasure:** Eliminate the cause; build supply alternatives.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever controls the foundation steers the effect.

20. Fish in Troubled Waters

- **Core idea:** Exploiting a lack of clarity.
- **Yang – Application:** Exploiting a confused situation.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Create transparency; sort out contradictory figures.
- **Switch:** Create a lack of clarity.
- **Case example:** Contradictory figures in a crisis; differing reporting statuses.
- **Countermeasure:** Uniform data basis; create order; document source and status.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever profits from confusion keeps it going.

21. The Cicada Sheds Its Shell

- **Core idea:** Leaving the outer shell behind.
- **Yang – Application:** Leaving the visible structure in place while shifting assets.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check real movements; trace responsibilities and assets.
- **Switch:** Use structures as a distraction.
- **Case example:** Restructuring as cover for relocating assets or rights.
- **Countermeasure:** Check responsibilities, accounts and rights, not the structural veneer.
- **Mirror thought:** The visible remains, the essential departs.

22. Shut the Door to Catch the Thief

- **Core idea:** Limiting options for action.
- **Yang – Application:** Restricting the options of the other.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Secure exit paths; check options in advance.
- **Switch:** Reduce room for evasion.
- **Case example:** High switching costs through technical lock-in.
- **Countermeasure:** Check portability and exit in advance and secure them contractually.
- **Mirror thought:** Control arises through loss of options.

23. Ally with the Distant, Attack the Near

- **Core idea:** Shaping alliances against those close by.
- **Yang – Application:** Deploying more distant partners against competitors.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Diversify dependencies; check the purpose of the alliance.
- **Switch:** Seek out more distant partners.
- **Case example:** Cooperation with a third party against a direct competitor.
- **Countermeasure:** Build your own partnerships; dependency analysis.
- **Mirror thought:** Alliances change dependencies.

24. Borrow the Road to Conquer Guo

- **Core idea:** Using access for something more far-reaching.
- **Yang – Application:** Asking for limited permission.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Restrict access narrowly; check purpose and scope.
- **Switch:** Use a request for access.
- **Case example:** IT maintenance access that is later used to obtain expanded rights.
- **Countermeasure:** Minimize rights; time-limit and log access.
- **Mirror thought:** Granted access brings influence.

Part V: Stratagems for Changing Positions (25–30)

25. Steal the Beams, Replace the Pillars

- **Core idea:** Altering load-bearing components.
- **Yang – Application:** Modifying system elements.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Review critical interventions; control responsibilities.
- **Switch:** Replace load-bearing elements.
- **Case example:** Approval rights are shifted step by step.
- **Countermeasure:** Review responsibilities and rights regularly; change log.
- **Mirror thought:** Small changes alter the whole system.

26. Point at the Mulberry Tree, Rebuke the Acacia Tree

- **Core idea:** Conveying a message indirectly.
- **Yang – Application:** Directing criticism at what is visible.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check the target of the message; distinguish the addressee from the party actually meant.
- **Switch:** Voice criticism via third parties.
- **Case example:** Public reprimand of one case as a warning to another group.
- **Countermeasure:** Recognize the purpose; do not react to the visible addressee but to the rule that is meant.
- **Mirror thought:** The visible addressee is not the target.

27. Feign Stupidity Without Losing Your Wits

- **Core idea:** Concealing capabilities.
- **Yang – Application:** Withholding knowledge.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Verify independently; do not infer competence from self-presentation.
- **Switch:** Conceal competence in measured doses.
- **Case example:** Feigning uninformedness in a negotiation in order to test prices.
- **Countermeasure:** Disclose in a controlled way; verify facts independently.
- **Mirror thought:** Visible competence deviates from real competence.

28. Remove the Ladder After the Opponent Has Climbed Up

- **Core idea:** Making retreat harder.
- **Yang – Application:** Leading into dependency, removing the way back.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Secure the exit in advance; check portability.
- **Switch:** Enable entries.
- **Case example:** A system change is made technically or contractually impossible.
- **Countermeasure:** Secure portability and exit clauses.
- **Mirror thought:** Access becomes a trap.

29. Hang Artificial Blossoms on Trees

- **Core idea:** Creating an impression of strength.
- **Yang – Application:** Staging resources.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check substance; operational performance instead of demo.
- **Switch:** Stage strength.
- **Case example:** A demo without everyday maturity; a presentation without reliable metrics.
- **Countermeasure:** Check operational performance, references and metrics.
- **Mirror thought:** The impression of strength is a means, not evidence.

30. Turn from Guest into Host

- **Core idea:** Changing position from bottom to top.
- **Yang – Application:** Expanding limited access.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Set clear boundaries; preserve control rights.
- **Switch:** Expand influence.
- **Case example:** A service provider becomes the de facto decision-maker.
- **Countermeasure:** Preserve control rights and decision-making authority; role clarification.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever has access determines the rules.

Part VI: Stratagems in Difficult Situations (31–36)

31. The Beauty Trap

- **Core idea:** Using emotional attachment.
- **Yang – Application:** Deploying needs.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Apply objective criteria; separate closeness and interest.
- **Switch:** Use relationship levels.
- **Case example:** An attractive offer with personal closeness that makes objective review harder.
- **Countermeasure:** Review objectively; set decision criteria before the conversation.
- **Mirror thought:** Emotions steer decisions.

32. The Empty City

- **Core idea:** Feigning calm or defenselessness.
- **Yang – Application:** Presenting the situation as unclear.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Gather information instead of believing the impression; assess independently.
- **Switch:** Create ambivalence.
- **Case example:** A calm reaction to an advance although the situation is tense.
- **Countermeasure:** Independent assessment; gather facts, do not read moods.
- **Mirror thought:** Uncertainty creates effect.

33. Turn the Opponent's Spy

- **Core idea:** Gaining a source of information.
- **Yang – Application:** Turning a spy into your own source.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Check sources; assess reliability.
- **Switch:** Influence channels.
- **Case example:** Internal information from the competitor whose origin is unclear.
- **Countermeasure:** Check reliability; document the information chain.
- **Mirror thought:** Whoever controls information steers decisions.

34. Injure Oneself

- **Core idea:** Feigning a disadvantage.
- **Yang – Application:** Accepting damage for the sake of credibility.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Examine the strategic gain; examine incentives.
- **Switch:** Present disadvantages.
- **Case example:** A public waiver that secures later access.
- **Countermeasure:** Examine incentives and follow-up business.
- **Mirror thought:** The sacrifice is a signal.

35. Chain Strategies

- **Core idea:** Linking measures.
- **Yang – Application:** Coordinating steps with one another.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Interrupt transitions; control steps separately.
- **Switch:** Build sequences.
- **Case example:** Trust, then rights, then function – in one sequence.
- **Countermeasure:** Review and approve each step separately.
- **Mirror thought:** The overall effect arises from the interplay.

36. Retreat as the Best Strategy

- **Core idea:** Ending the conflict when at a disadvantage.
- **Yang – Application:** Preserving forces.
- **Yin – Recognition:** Read retreat as reorientation, not as weakness.
- **Switch:** Withdraw in good time.
- **Case example:** A loss-making price war is ended and resources are realigned.
- **Countermeasure:** Realign; examine retreat as a strategic option.
- **Mirror thought:** Retreat changes the conditions.

4 When Both Play Mirror-Aware

The presentation so far has considered each stratagem in isolation. The real core question is: What happens when both sides know the model – when Yang meets Yin and both master the role switch?

4.1 The Feedback Loop

As soon as both sides act mirror-aware, a feedback loop emerges:

1. A applies a Yang pattern.
2. B recognizes it (Yin) and chooses a countermeasure.
3. A recognizes the countermeasure and changes the pattern (Switch).
4. B anticipates the switch and chooses a counter-Yin.

This sequence is not an equilibrium in the game-theoretic sense. It can proceed in three directions:

- **Escalation:** The loop builds up (mirroring, spiral of distrust, over-arming – see 4.2).
- **Termination:** One side chooses de-escalation or retreat (Stratagem 36, Stratagem 9 – see 4.3).
- **Structure formation:** The loop leads into a third structure – a new rule, an alliance, an institutional agreement – that is no longer described by the original patterns.

The model describes the dynamics, not their outcome. Which outcome occurs is an empirical question, not a model prediction.

4.2 Escalation Dynamics

Mirror-aware play carries a risk of escalation:

- **Mirroring effects:** Both sides use the same pattern.
- **Spirals of distrust:** Yin is interpreted as Yang.
- **Over-arming:** Redundancies and controls tie up resources.

4.3 De-escalation as a Strategic Option

Escalation is not inevitable in this model. Stratagem 36 (Retreat) and Stratagem 9 (Observing) show: non-action and retreat are legitimate strategic decisions. De-escalation is not a defeat but a change of position – and thus itself a strategic operation.

5 Revised Example Systematics

The following table replaces the generic examples with case-based scenarios with a concrete check step. It is intended as a working grid, not as an exhaustive list.

Case type	Typical Yang application	Yin check step (checklist)	Typical countermeasure
Negotiation	Delay, bait, “stupidity”	**Option preservation:** Which alternatives are disappearing? **Cui bono:** Who benefits from the time consumed?	Set deadlines; negotiate alternatives in parallel; verify facts independently
Organization	Creeping shift of rights	**Boundary setting:** Where does my mandate end? **Information hygiene:** What is communicated, what is real?	Clear boundaries; review points; log rights changes
Information environment	Targeted leaks, framing, apparent threat	**Information hygiene:** Claim vs. evidence? Check origin and motive	Source verification; separation of facts; second source

Case type	Typical Yang application	Yin check step (checklist)	Typical countermeasure
Alliances	Distant partners against those close by	**Cui bono:** Who benefits from the alliance? **Option preservation:** Do my own alternatives remain?	Dependency analysis; own partnerships; exit options
Crisis	Exploitation of time pressure and lack of clarity	**All six operations:** information, options, beneficiaries, boundaries, time, escalation	Emergency decoupling; uniform data basis; separate negotiation of emergency and regular matters
Access / rights	Limited permission is expanded	**Boundary setting:** Scope of access? Purpose?	Minimize rights; time-limiting; logging

Application: The checklist from Section 2.2 is worked through before every countermeasure. The table provides the typical case type and the probably relevant core operation – but does not replace the check.

5.1 Worked Case Example as a Model

Case example: The “routine” maintenance access (Stratagems 1, 24, 30)

Situation: An IT service provider receives time-limited access to a core system “for routine maintenance.” After three months it turns out that the access has been expanded: new approval rights, access to customer data, participation in architecture decisions.

Yang analysis (what happened):

- **Stratagem 1 (Deceive the Heavens):** Maintenance as “routine normality” – no reason for review.
- **Stratagem 24 (Borrow the Road):** Limited permission is used for something more far-reaching.
- **Stratagem 30 (Turn from Guest into Host):** From service provider to de facto decision-maker.

Yin analysis (checklist):

- **Information hygiene:** What is “maintenance,” what is “further development”? Contract text vs. actual activity.
- **Option preservation:** What alternatives does the service provider have? What do we have?
- **Cui bono:** Who profits from the expansion? Who steers it?
- **Boundary setting:** Where does the mandate end? Which rights have been granted?
- **Time control:** Who dictates the deadlines of the “maintenance windows”?
- **Escalation control:** What does a hard limitation trigger? (Answer: probably renegotiation – examine the de-escalation option.)

Countermeasure: Minimize rights (boundary setting); time-limiting and logging (time control); role clarification service provider/decision-maker (option preservation); contractual separation of maintenance and further development (information hygiene).

Mirror thought: Whoever has access determines the rules – and whoever determines the rules no longer needs access.

What the example shows: The three stratagems are not independent – they form a chain (Stratagem 35). The checklist makes visible that the countermeasure must start at several points, not only one.

6 Limits of the Model

The model does not claim to reconstruct historically transmitted Yin versions or to possess empirically demonstrated superiority. It is a didactic and analytical tool.

Explicitly named limits:

1. **No predictive power:** The model describes possibilities, not probabilities. It does not predict which pattern will be chosen.
2. **No equilibrium analysis:** The feedback loop in Chapter 4 is a description, not a formal equilibrium concept. For formal analysis, game theory is the more suitable tool.
3. **Cultural context:** The 36 stratagems are historically and culturally situated. The mirror thesis is a modern reconstruction, not a historical reading.
4. **Risk of misuse:** A tool that teaches countermeasures also teaches how to circumvent countermeasures. This is inherent and cannot be remedied by wording.
5. **Editorial limit:** The number 72 is arithmetic, not a theoretical contribution.
6. **Mnemonic formulas instead of analysis:** The mirror thoughts are didactic mnemonic formulas, not independent analytical tools. They repeat the core idea in different grammar.
7. **Limited case depth:** The worked case example in 5.1 is a model, not a collection. Anyone using the document as a practical handbook must work out the cases themselves.

7 Distinction from Related Approaches

Approach	Relationship to the mirror model
Red teaming	Practices Yin as an institutional role – more systematic than the mirror model, but without its didactic doubling of perspective.
Pre-mortem	Anticipates failure prospectively; the mirror model reconstructs the counter-logic retrospectively and prospectively.
OODA loop	Describes decision cycles (Observe, Orient, Decide, Act); the mirror model supplies the substantive content of the “Orient” phase.
Game theory	Formal equilibrium analysis; the mirror model is qualitative and descriptive, no substitute for formal analysis.

8 Concluding Reflection

The analysis shows: Each of the 36 patterns can be viewed from the perspective of the applier and of the affected party. These are not 72 mutually independent tricks, but 36 patterns whose logic of effect can be understood from two directions and actively switched. That is the core of the mirror thesis.

What the model achieves: It makes the Yin side operational – through six testable core operations, an application checklist, a case-based example systematics and a worked case example as a model. It teaches not only applying, but recognizing and counteracting.

What the model does not achieve: It is not a theory of strategic equilibria, not a prediction machine and not a historical reconstruction. The number 72 is arithmetic. The strength lies in didactic clarity, not in theoretical novelty.

The real gain lies in Chapter 4: Whoever understands that both sides can play mirror-aware stops reading stratagems as a list of tricks and begins to understand them as a dynamic sequence – with three possible outcomes (escalation, termination, structure formation) and de-escalation as a legitimate strategic option.

9 Glossary

Yang
Active application of a stratagem.

Yin
Recognition and countermeasure from the perspective of the affected party.

Switch
Conscious transition between roles.

Mirror thought
The insight of the dual logic – the same logic of effect applies to both sides but shows itself differently depending on position. *Note: mnemonic formula, not an independent analytical tool.*

Yin core operation
One of the six testable guiding questions (information hygiene, option preservation, cui bono, boundary setting, time control, escalation control).

Checklist
Fixed order of the six core operations before every countermeasure (first recognize 1–4, then act and check 5–6).

Feedback loop
Dynamic sequence of Yang, Yin, Switch and counter-Yin when both sides play mirror-aware. Three possible outcomes: escalation, termination, structure formation.

Structure formation
Outcome of the feedback loop in which a third structure (rule, alliance, agreement) emerges that is no longer described by the original patterns.

End of the complete edition. Editorial note: Duplicate entries were merged, fragmented passages put in order, the example systematics replaced by case-based check steps, the checklist expanded from four to six core operations, the feedback loop supplemented by the outcome "structure formation," a worked case example inserted as a model and the limits of the model explicitly named.